

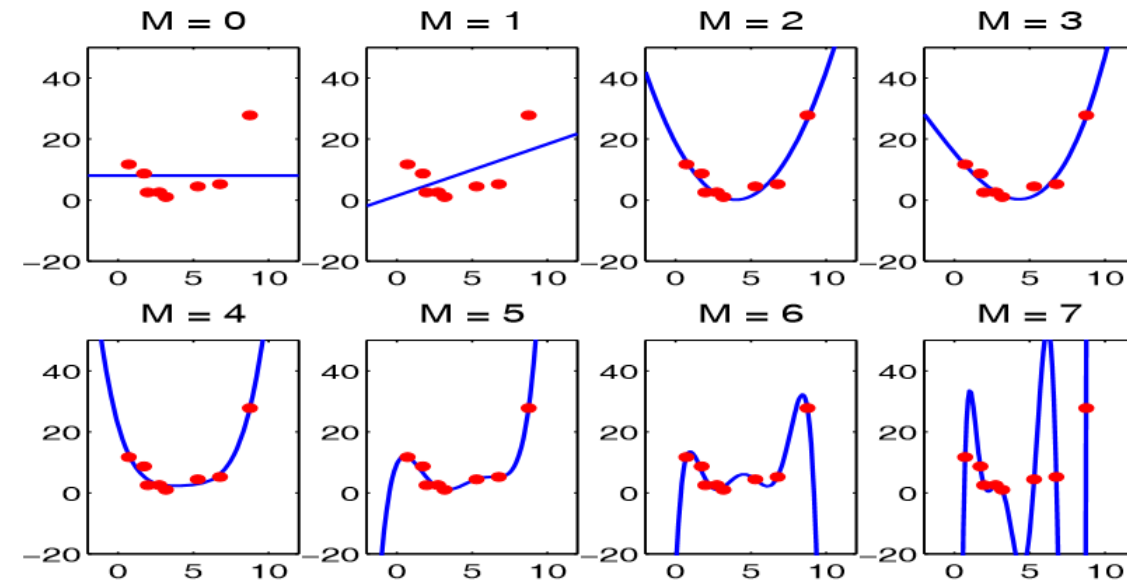
CPSC 340: Machine Learning and Data Mining

Feature Selection

Last Time: Finding the “True” Model

- What if y_i really is a polynomial function of x_i ?
 - How can we find the “true” degree ‘ p ’ of the polynomial?

- Training error does not work:
 - It goes down as ‘ p ’ goes up.
- Cross-validation may also not work:
 - Tends to overestimate ‘ p ’.
 - Due to optimization bias.



For example, imagine that the true model is $y_i = 2x_i^2 - 5 + (\text{noise})$

We might choose $d=3$ and a model like $\hat{y}_i = 0.001x_i^3 + 2x_i^2 - 5$,

since it might get a slightly smaller validation error.

Last Time: Complexity Penalties

- We discussed putting a **penalty on the model complexity**.
 - Want to **fit the data and have a simple model**.

Find 'v' and 'p' minimizing:

$$\text{score}(p) = \underbrace{\frac{1}{2} \|Z_p v - y\|^2}_{\text{usual error}} + \underbrace{\lambda K}_{\substack{\text{"strength"} \\ \text{of penalty}}} \quad \rightarrow \text{"number of degrees of freedom"} \\ \text{(K=p+1 for degree-P polynomial)}$$

- “To increase the degrees of freedom by one, need to decrease error by λ ”.
- Prefers smaller degrees of freedom, if errors are similar.
 - **Can't optimize this using gradient descent**, since it's discontinuous in 'p'.
 - Need to search over values of 'p'.

Bayesian Information Criterion (BIC)

- A disadvantage of these methods:
 - Still **prefers a larger ‘p’ as ‘n’ grows.**
- Solution: make **λ depend on ‘n’.**
- For example, the **Bayesian information criterion (BIC)** uses:
$$\lambda = \frac{1}{2} \log(n)$$
- BIC penalizes a bit more than AIC for large ‘n’.
 - As ‘n’ goes to ∞ , recovers “true” model (“consistent” for model selection).
- In practice, we usually just **try a bunch of different λ values.**
 - Picking λ is like picking ‘k’ in k-means.

Discussion of other Scores for Model Selection

- There are many **other scores**:
 - Elbow method (corresponds to specific choice of λ).
 - You could also use BIC for choosing ‘k’ in k-means.
 - Methods based on validation error.
 - “Take smallest ‘p’ within one standard error of minimum cross-validation error”.
 - Minimum description length.
 - Risk inflation criterion.
 - False discovery rate.
 - Marginal likelihood (CPSC 440).
- These can adapted to use the L1-norm and other errors.

Next Topic: Feature Selection

Motivation: Discovering Food Allergies

- Recall the food allergy example:

Egg	Milk	Fish	Wheat	Shellfish	Peanuts	...		Sick?
0	0.7	0	0.3	0	0		→	1
0.3	0.7	0	0.6	0	0.01		→	1
0	0	0	0.8	0	0		→	0
0.3	0.7	1.2	0	0.10	0.01		→	1

- What I want to know **which foods** are making me sick?
 - Rather than building a black box that tells me if I will be sick.
- Instead of prediction, we want to do **feature selection**:
 - Which foods are “relevant” for predicting “sick”.

Feature Selection

- General feature selection problem:

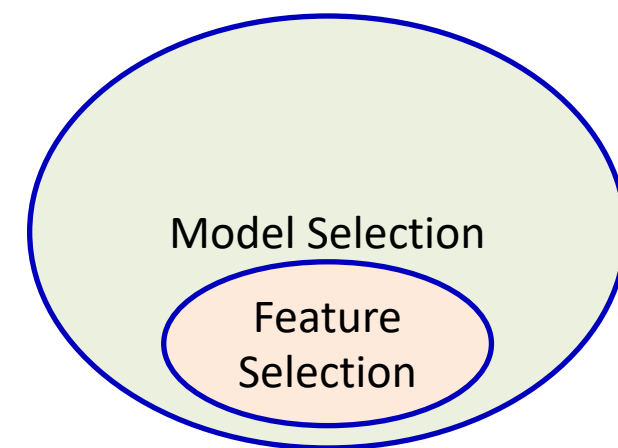
selection problem.

$X = \begin{bmatrix} \text{feature 'j'} \\ \vdots \end{bmatrix}$ $y = \begin{bmatrix} \vdots \end{bmatrix}$

- Find the features (columns) of 'X' that are important for predicting 'y'.
 - “What are the relevant factors?”
 - “Which basis functions should I use among these choices?”
 - “What types of new data should I collect?”
 - “How can I speed up computation?”
- One of most important problems in ML/statistics, but very messy.
 - For now, we will say a feature is “relevant” if it helps predict y_i from x_i .

Digression: “Feature” vs. “Model” Selection?

- **Model selection**: “which model should I use?”
 - KNN vs. decision tree, depth of decision tree, **degree of polynomial basis**.
- **Feature selection**: “which features should I use?”
 - Using feature 10 or not, **using x_i^2 as part of basis**.
- These two tasks are **highly-related**:
 - It is a different “model” if we add x_i^2 to linear regression.
 - But the x_i^2 term is just a “feature” that could be “selected” or not.
 - Usually, “feature selection” means choosing from some “original” features.
 - You could say that “feature” selection is a special case of “model” selection.

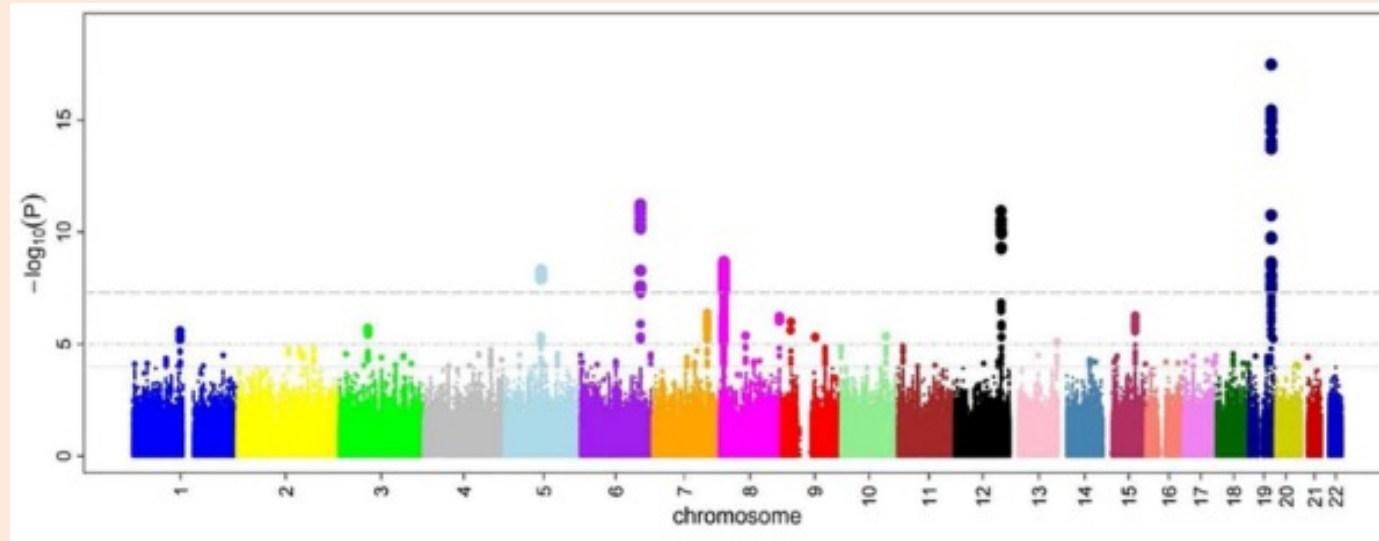


“Association” Approach to Feature Selection

- A simple/common way to do feature selection:
 - For each feature ‘j’, compute correlation between feature values x_j and ‘y’.
 - Say that ‘j’ is relevant if correlation is above 0.5 or below -0.5.
- Turns feature selection into hypothesis testing for each feature.
 - There are many other measures of “dependence” ([Wikipedia](#)).
- Usually gives unsatisfactory results as it ignores variable interactions:
 - Includes irrelevant variables: “Taco Tuesdays”.
 - If tacos make you sick, and you often eat tacos on Tuesdays, it will say “Tuesday” is relevant.
 - Excludes relevant variables: “Diet Coke + Mentos Eruption”.
 - Diet coke and Mentos don’t make you sick on their own, but *together* they make you sick.

Genome-Wide Association Studies

- Genome-wide association studies:
 - Measure if there exists a dependency between each individual “single-nucleotide polymorphism” in the genome and a particular disease.



- Has identified thousands of genes “associated” with diseases.
 - But *by design* this has a **huge numbers of false positives** (and many false negatives).

Feature Selection in Linear Models: “Find $w_j \neq 0$ ”

- In linear models, **setting $w_j = 0$ is the same as removing feature ‘j’**:

$$\hat{y}_i = w_1 x_{i1} + w_2 x_{i2} + w_3 x_{i3} + \dots + w_d x_{id}$$

$$\hat{y}_i = w_1 x_{i1} + \underbrace{0}_{\text{ignore } x_{i2}} + w_3 x_{i3} + \dots + w_d x_{id}$$

$\underbrace{\hspace{1.5cm}}_{\text{set } w_2 = 0}$

- So “feature selection” is finding **w_j values that are not zero**.

If $w = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ 2 \\ 0 \\ 3 \end{bmatrix}$ then we “select” features 1, 3 and 5

- However, standard regression methods tend to **set all $w_j \neq 0$** .
 - So they **select all features**.

“Regression Weight” Approach to Feature Selection

- Another simple/common approach to feature selection:
 - Fit regression weights ‘w’ based on **all** features (maybe with least squares).
 - Take all features ‘j’ where **weight $|w_j|$ is greater than a threshold**.
- For example: you fit a least squares model with 5 features and get:

$$w = \begin{bmatrix} 0.01 \\ -0.2 \\ 10 \\ -3 \\ 0.0001 \end{bmatrix}$$

- Feature 3 looks the most relevant.
- Feature 4 also looks relevant.
- Feature 5 seems irrelevant.

“Regression Weight” Approach to Feature Selection

- Another simple/common approach to feature selection:
 - Fit regression weights ‘ w ’ based on **all** features (maybe with least squares).
 - Take all features ‘ j ’ where **weight $|w_j|$ is greater than a threshold.**
- This could recognize that “Tuesday” is irrelevant.
 - It could assign a large weight to “tacos”, and a small weight to “Tuesday”.
 - Since the tacos would “explain” the correlation between “Tuesday” and “sick”.
 - Assuming you get enough data, and you sometimes eat tacos on other days.
(And the relationship is actually linear.)

“Regression Weight” Approach to Feature Selection

- Another simple/common approach to feature selection:
 - Fit regression weights ‘w’ based on **all** features (maybe with least squares).
 - Take all features ‘j’ where **weight $|w_j|$ is greater than a threshold**.

- Has **major problems with collinearity**:

- If the “Tuesday” variable always equals the “taco” variable, it **could say that Tuesdays are relevant but tacos are not**.

$$\hat{y}_i = w_1 * \text{taco} + w_2 * \text{Tuesday} = 0 * \text{taco} + (w_1 + w_2) * \text{Tuesday}$$

- If you have two copies of an irrelevant feature, it **could take both irrelevant copies**.

$$\hat{y}_i = 0 * \text{irrelevant} + 0 * \text{irrelevant} = 10000 * \text{irrelevant} + (-10000) * \text{irrelevant}$$

Can it help prediction to throw features away?

- Yes, because **we can overfit** with large 'd'.
 - Even in linear regression where it is “just” a hyper-plane.
- Consider using $d=n$, with random features: $X=\text{randn}(n,d)$.
 - With high probability, you will be able to **get a training error of 0**.
 - But the features were random, this is **completely overfitting**.
- You could view “**number of features**” as a **hyper-parameter**.
 - Model gets more complex as you add more features.

Next Topic: Search and Score Methods

Search and Score Methods

- Most common feature selection framework is **search and score**:
 1. Define **score function** $f(S)$ that measures quality of a set of features 'S'.
 2. Now **search** for the variables 'S' with the best score.
- Example with 3 features:
 - Compute “score” of selecting only feature 1.
 - Compute “score” of selecting only feature 2.
 - Compute “score” of selecting only feature 3.
 - Compute “score” of selecting only features {1,2}.
 - Compute “score” of selecting only features {1,3}.
 - Compute “score” of selecting only features {2,3}.
 - Compute “score” of selecting all features {1,2,3}.
 - Compute “score” of selecting no features {}.
 - Return the set of features 'S' with the best “score”.

Which Score Function?

- The **score cannot be the training error**.
 - Training error goes down as you add features, so will **select all features**.
- A more logical score is the **validation error**.
 - “**Find the set of features that gives the lowest validation error.**”
 - To minimize test error, this is what we want.
- But there are problems due to the **large number of sets** of variables:
 - If we have ‘d’ variables, there are **2^d sets** of variables.
 - **Optimization bias** is high: we’re optimizing over 2^d models (not 10).
 - So prone to **false positives**: irrelevant variables will sometimes help by chance.

“Number of Features” Penalties

- To reduce false positives, we can again use **complexity penalties**:

$$\text{score}(S) = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{i=1}^n (w_S^T x_{iS} - y_i)^2 + \lambda \text{size}(S)$$

- We’re using ‘ x_{iS} ’ as the features ‘ S ’ of example x_i .
- Above we minimize **squared error** plus a penalty on **number of features**.
 - “You can include an extra feature if it **reduces training error by at least λ** .”
- If two ‘ S ’ have similar error, this **prefers the smaller set**.
 - It **prefers removing feature 3 instead of having $w_3 = 0.00001$** .

“L0-Norm” and “Number of Features We Use”

- To reduce false positives, we can again use **complexity penalties**:

$$\text{score}(S) = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{i=1}^n (w_s^T x_{is} - y_i)^2 + \lambda \text{size}(S)$$

- We often use this using the “**L0-norm**” instead of writing “size(S)”...

$$\text{score}(S) = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{i=1}^n (w_s^T x_{is} - y_i)^2 + \lambda \|w\|_0$$

- The L0 “norm” is the **number of non-zero values** ($\|w\|_0 = \text{size}(S)$).

$$\text{If } w = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ 2 \\ 0 \\ 3 \end{bmatrix} \text{ then } \|w\|_0 = 3 \quad \text{If } w = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ 0 \\ 0 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix} \text{ then } \|w\|_0 = 0.$$

- If ‘w’ has a small L0-norm, then it does not use many features.
- **Not actually a true norm** (not convex, for example).

Interpretation of the L0-Norm Penalty

- L0-norm penalty for feature selection:

$$f(w) = \frac{1}{2} \|Xw - y\|^2 + \lambda \|w\|_0$$

- Balances between training error and number of features we use.
 - For $\lambda=0$, we get least squares with all features (no penalty on non-zeroes).
 - For $\lambda=\infty$, we must set $w=0$ and not use any features (infinite penalty).
 - For other λ , balances between training error and number of non-zeroes.
 - Larger λ puts more emphasis on having zeroes in 'w' (more features removed).
 - Different values give AIC, BIC, and so on.

Evaluating the Score with the L0-Norm Penalty

- L0-norm penalty for feature selection:

$$f(w) = \underbrace{\frac{1}{2} \|Xw - y\|^2}_{\text{training error}} + \underbrace{\lambda \|w\|_0}_{\text{degrees of freedom 'k'}}$$

- Suppose we want to use this to evaluate the features $S = \{1, 2\}$:
 - First fit the 'w' just using features 1 and 2.
 - Now compute the training error with this 'w' and features 1 and 2.
 - Add $\lambda * 2$ to the training error to get the score.
- We repeat this with other choices of 'S' to find the “best” features.
 - But there are still 2^d possible sets of features.

Forward Selection (Greedy Search Heuristic)

- A common greedy search procedure is **forward selection**:
 - Greedy algorithm that **adds one feature at a time**.

It is like
building
tree

greedy

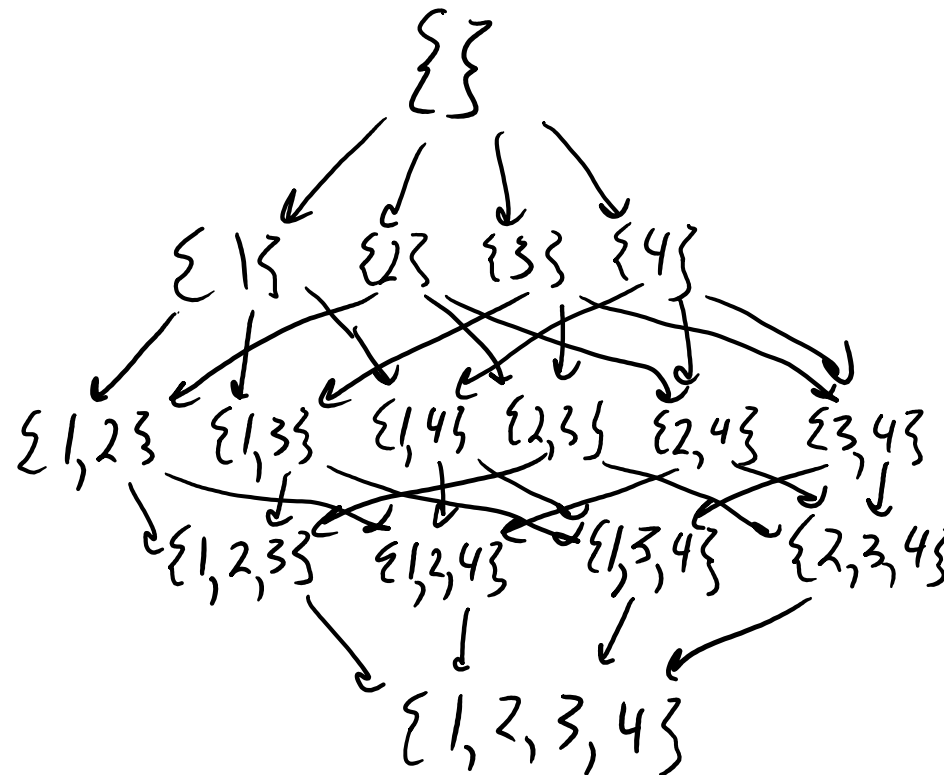
1. Compute score if we use no features.
2. Try adding "taco", "milk", "egg", and so on (computing score of each)
3. Add "milk" because it got the best score.
4. Try {milk, taco}, {milk, egg}, and so on (computing score of each variable with milk)
5. Add "egg" because it got the best score combined with "milk"
6. Try {milk, egg, taco}, {milk, egg, pizza}, and so on...

Forward Selection (Greedy Search Heuristic)

- **Forward selection** algorithm for variable selection:
 1. Start with an **empty set** of features, $S = \{\}$.
 2. For each possible feature 'j':
 - **Compute scores of features in 'S' combined with feature 'j'.**
 3. Find the 'j' that has the best score when added to 'S'.
 4. Check if $\{S \cup j\}$ improves on the best score found so far.
 5. Add 'j' to 'S' and go back to Step 2.
 - A variation is to **stop if no 'j' improves the score** over just using 'S'.
- Runtime of forward selection:
 - We **fit $O(d^2)$ models**, out of the 2^d possible models with different features → All Combination
 - Each step requires fitting up to 'd' models, and there are up to 'd' steps.
 - Total cost will be **$O(d^2)$ times the cost of fitting an individual model.** → $O(d^2)$
 - See bonus for the case of least squares, and how you fit "updated" model faster than re-fitting.
- **Not guaranteed to find the best** set, but fitting fewer models **reduces many problems**:
 - Cheaper, overfits less, has fewer false positives.

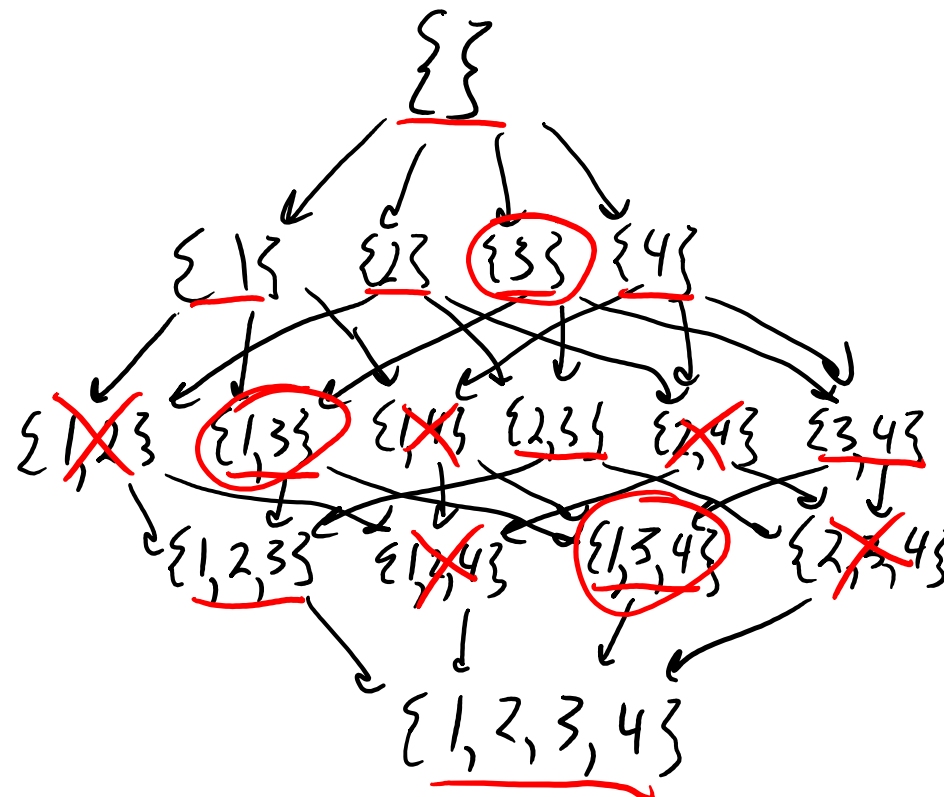
Forward Selection (Greedy Search Heuristic)

- Consider **all sets of 4** variables:



Forward Selection (Greedy Search Heuristic)

- Consider **all sets of 4** variables:
 - Greedy method considers **at most 4 sets at each level**.
 - Instead of 2^4** possible sets.



← Set with 0 variables

← Sets with 1 variable

← Sets with 2 variables

← Sets with 3 variables

← Set with 4 variables

Backward Selection and RFE

- **Forward selection** often works better than naïve methods.
- A related method is **backward selection**:
 - Start with all features, compute score after removing each feature, remove the one that improves the score the most.
- If you consider adding or removing features, it's called **stagewise selection**.
- **Stochastic local search** is a class of fancier methods.
 - Simulated annealing, genetic algorithms, ant colony optimization, etc.
- **Recursive feature elimination** is another related method:
 - Fit parameters of a regression model, prune features with small regression weights, repeat.
- See bonus slide for discussion of **feature selection in random forests**.

Next Topic: Ambiguity of Feature Selection

Is “Relevance” Clearly Defined?

- Consider a supervised classification task:

Parent A	Parent B	Partner
1	0	0
0	1	1
0	0	1
1	1	1

Eye
0
0
0
1

- Predict whether an individual has blue eyes or not
 - Depends on both parents, does not depend on partner

Is “Relevance” Clearly Defined?

- Consider a supervised classification task:

Parent A	Parent B	Partner
1	0	0
0	1	1
0	0	1
1	1	1

Eye
0
0
0
1

- True model:
 - (Eye = Parent A & Parent B) with high probability.
 - (Eye != Parent A & Parent B) with some very low probability.
- What are the “relevant” features for this problem?

Is “Relevance” Clearly Defined?

- What if “Parent A” feature is repeated?

Parent A	Parent B	Partner	Parent A (2)
1	0	0	1
0	1	1	0
0	0	1	0
1	1	1	1

Eye
0
0
0
1

- Are “Parent A” and “Parent A (2)” relevant?
 - Should we pick them both?
 - Should we pick one because it predicts the other?
- If features can be predicted from features, **can’t know which to pick**.
 - Collinearity is a special case of “dependence” (which may be non-linear).

Neither of these is “correct”, but not picking either is incorrect.

Is “Relevance” Clearly Defined?

- What if we add grandparents?

Parent A	Parent B	Partner	Grandparent
1	0	0	1
0	1	1	1
0	0	1	0
1	1	1	1

Eye
0
0
0
1

- Is “Grandparent” relevant?
 - May be relevant, especially if I know about all grandparents
 - But **irrelevant if I know “Parent A” and “Parent B”**.
 - There is no information gained from if you already know about parents.

Is “Relevance” Clearly Defined?

- What if we don't know “Parent A”?

Parent B	Grandparent	Partner
0	1	0
1	0	1
0	0	1
1	1	1

Eye
0
0
0
1

- Now is “Grandparent” relevant?
 - Without both parent variables, maybe it is the best you can do.
- A feature is **only “relevant” in the context of available features.**
 - Adding/removing features can make features relevant/irrelevant.

Summary

- **Feature selection** is task of choosing the “relevant” features.
 - Obvious simple approaches have obvious simple problems.
- **Search and score**: find features that optimize some score.
 - **L0-norm penalties** are the most common scores.
 - **Forward selection** is a heuristic to search over a smaller set of features.
- **“Relevance”** depends on context.
 - Adding/removing features can make things relevant/irrelevant.
- Next time: getting a good test error even with irrelevant features.

Feature Selection in Random Forests

- Decision trees naturally do feature selection while learning:
 - The features used for the splits are the ones that are “selected”.
- There are a variety of ways to evaluate features in random forests:
 - Compute proportion of trees that use feature ‘j’.
 - Compute average infogain increase when using feature ‘j’.
 - Permute all values of feature ‘j’, and see how “out of bag” error increases.
- You could use any of above to select features from random forest.

Mallow's Cp

- Older than AIC and BIC is **Mallow's Cp**:

$$f(w) = \frac{\|Xw - y\|^2}{\frac{1}{n}\|\hat{X}\hat{w} - y\|^2} - n + 2\|w\|_0$$

least squares weights if we used all features.

- Minimizing this score is equivalent to L0-regularization:

$$f(w) = \frac{1}{2}\|Xw - y\|^2 + \lambda\|w\|_0$$

$$\text{with } \lambda = \frac{\|\hat{X}\hat{w} - y\|^2}{n}$$

- So again, viewing λ as hyper-parameter, this score is special case.

Adjusted R^2

- Older than AIC and BIC and Mallow's C_p is **adjusted R^2** :

$$f(w) = 1 - (1 - R^2) \frac{n-1}{n - \|w\|_0 - 1} \quad \text{where} \quad R^2 = 1 - \frac{\|Xw - y\|^2}{\|X\hat{w} - y\|^2}$$

- Maximizing this score is equivalent to L0-regularization:

$$= \frac{1}{2} \|Xw - y\|^2 + \lambda \|w\|_0$$

$$\text{with } \lambda = \frac{\|X\hat{w} - y\|^2}{2(n-1)}$$

- So again, viewing λ as hyper-parameter, this score is special case.

ANOVA

- Some people also like to compute this “ANOVA” quantity:

$$f(w) = \frac{\|Xw - \bar{y}\|^2}{\|y - \bar{y}\|^2}$$

mean of y_i values repeated n times

- This is based on the decomposition of “total squared error” as:

$$\underbrace{\|y - \bar{y}\|^2}_{\text{“total” error}} = \underbrace{\|Xw - \bar{y}\|^2}_{\text{“explained” error}} + \underbrace{\|Xw - y\|^2}_{\text{“residual” (usual) error}}$$

- Notice that “explained error” goes up as our usual (“residual”) error goes down.
- Trying to find the ‘k’ features that maximize ‘f’ (“explain the most variance”) is equivalent to L0-regularization with a particular λ (so another special case).

Information Criteria with Noise Variance

- We defined AIC/BIC for feature selection in least squares as:

$$f(w) = \frac{1}{2} \|Xw - y\|^2 + \lambda \|w\|_0$$

- The first term comes from assuming $y_i = w^T x_i + \varepsilon$, where ε comes from a normal distribution with a variance of 1.
 - We'll discuss why when we discuss MLE and MAP estimation.
 - If you aren't doing least squares, replace first term by "log-likelihood".
- If you treat variance as a parameter, then after some manipulation:

$$f(w) = \frac{n}{2} \log(\|Xw - y\|^2) + \lambda \|w\|_0$$

- However, this is again equivalent to just changing λ .

Complexity Penalties for Other Models

- Scores like AIC and BIC can also be used in other contexts:
 - When fitting a decision tree, only split a node if it improves BIC.
 - This makes sense if we're looking for the “true tree”, or maybe just a simple/interpretable tree that performs well.
- In these cases we replace “L0-norm” with “degrees of freedom”.
 - In linear models fit with least squares, degrees of freedom is number of non-zeroes.
 - Unfortunately, it is not always easy to measure “degrees of freedom”.

Cost of Forward Selection

- Each step of forward selection fits up to 'd' model.
- And we do 'd' steps of forward selection.
- So cost of forward selection is $O(d^2)$ times cost of fitting one model.
- For linear regression with squared error, cost is $O(nd^2 + d^3)$.
 - So total cost of forward selection would be $O(nd^4 + d^5)$.

Faster Forward Selection for Least Squares

- Instead of fitting models from scratch, we can often speed up forward selection by **re-using computation and/or updating** models.
- For linear regression with the squared error:
 - Can reduce $O(nd^4)$ term from repeatedly compute $O(d^2)$ sub-matrices of $X^T X$:
 - Compute $X^T X$ once for all, then grab relevant sub-matrix for each model.
 - Costs $O(nd^2)$ to compute $X^T X$, then $O(d^2)$ to grab each sub-matrix.
 - Reduces cost of this step to $O(nd^2 + d^4)$.
 - Can reduce $O(d^5)$ term from solving $O(d^2)$ linear systems involving sub-matrices of $X^T X$:
 - Each time you add or remove a feature, it is a rank-1 update to the sub-matrix of $X^T X$.
 - By storing factorized $X^T X$ sub-matrix, you could do a rank-1 update for $O(d^2)$.
 - And cost of solving a linear system for a factorized matrix is also $O(d^2)$.
 - Total cost is $O(d^4)$ to do this $O(d^2)$ times.
 - So by updating models, can reduce cost from $O(nd^4 + d^5)$ down to $O(nd^2 + d^4)$.
 - Which is **similar to cost of solving one least squares problem**, particularly if $n \gg d$.

Structure Learning: Unsupervised Feature Selection

- “News” data: presence of 100 words in 16k newsgroup posts:

car	drive	files	hockey	mac	league	pc	win
0	0	1	0	1	0	1	0
0	0	0	1	0	1	0	1
1	1	0	0	0	0	0	0
0	1	1	0	1	0	0	0
0	0	1	0	0	0	1	1

- Which words are related to each other?
- Problem of **structure learning**: **unsupervised feature selection**.

- Structure:
-
- ```
graph TD; email --> ftp; email --> phone; ftp --> files; phone --> number; files --> disk; files --> format; files --> windows; disk --> drive; disk --> memory; disk --> system; drive --> car; drive --> scsi; drive --> data; car --> bmw; car --> dealer; car --> engine; car --> honda; car --> mac; engine --> oil; memory --> data; system --> problem; system --> display; problem --> help; display --> server; format --> image; image --> graphics; graphics --> server; windows --> card; windows --> dos; windows --> driver; windows --> pc; windows --> program; windows --> version; card --> graphics; dos --> video; driver --> software; pc --> space; program --> space; version --> space; space --> launch; space --> moon; space --> nasa; space --> orbit; space --> shuttle; space --> technology; space --> mission; launch --> lunar; moon --> mars; nasa --> earth; orbit --> satellite; shuttle --> solar; technology --> mission; mission --> god; god --> bible; god --> christian; god --> jesus; god --> religion; religion --> jews; jews --> government; jews --> israel; government --> children; government --> power; government --> president; government --> rights; government --> state; government --> war; children --> health; power --> human; president --> fact; rights --> law; state --> university; war --> world; health --> aids; health --> food; health --> insurance; health --> medicine; aids --> msg; food --> water; insurance --> patients; medicine --> studies; patients --> cancer; patients --> disease; patients --> doctor; patients --> vitamin; studies --> case; fact --> course; fact --> evidence; fact --> question; law --> gun; university --> research; world --> science; science --> computer;
```

# Naïve Approach: Association Networks

- A naïve approach to structure learning (“association networks”):
  - For each pair of variables, compute a measure of similarity or dependence.
- Using these  $n^2$  similarity values either:
  - Select all pairs whose similarity is above a threshold.
  - Select the “top  $k$ ” most similar features to each feature ‘j’.
- Main problems:
  - Usually, most variables are dependent (too many edges).
    - “Sick” is getting connected to “Tuesdays” even if “tacos” are a variable.
  - “True” neighbours may not have the highest dependence.
    - “Sick” might get connected to “Tuesdays” before it gets connected to “milk”.
- (Variation: best tree can be found as minimum spanning tree problem.)

# Example: Vancouver Rain Data

- Consider modeling the “Vancouver rain” dataset.

|         | Day 1 | Day 2 | Day 3 | Day 4 | Day 5 | Day 6 | Day 7 | Day 8 | Day 9 | ... |
|---------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-----|
| Month 1 | 0     | 0     | 0     | 1     | 1     | 0     | 0     | 1     | 1     |     |
| Month 2 | 1     | 0     | 0     | 0     | 0     | 0     | 1     | 0     | 0     |     |
| Month 3 | 1     | 1     | 1     | 1     | 1     | 1     | 1     | 1     | 1     |     |
| Month 4 | 1     | 1     | 1     | 1     | 0     | 0     | 1     | 1     | 1     |     |
| Month 5 | 0     | 0     | 0     | 0     | 1     | 1     | 0     | 0     | 0     |     |
| Month 6 | 0     | 1     | 1     | 0     | 0     | 0     | 0     | 1     | 1     |     |

- The strongest signal in the data is the simple relationship:
  - If it rained yesterday, it’s likely to rain today ( $> 50\%$  chance that  $x^{t-1} = x^t$ ).
  - But an “association network” might connect all days (all dependent).

# Dependency Networks

- A better approach is **dependency networks**:
  - For each variable 'j', **make it the target in a supervised learning problem.**

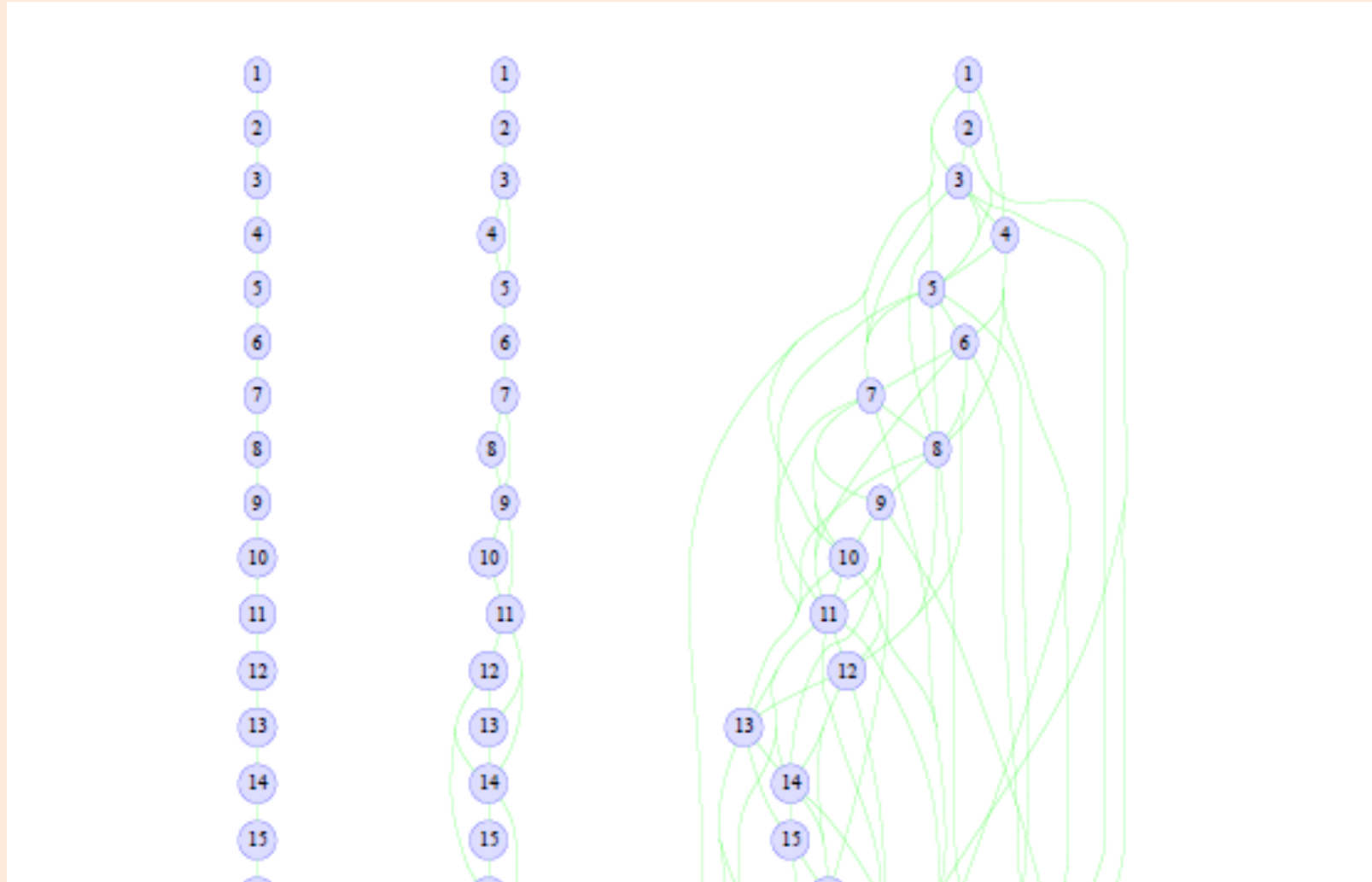
$$X = \begin{bmatrix} | & | & | & | & | \\ x^1 & x^2 & x^3 & x^4 & x^5 \\ | & | & | & | & | \end{bmatrix} \Rightarrow \bar{X} = \begin{bmatrix} | & | & | & | \\ x^1 & x^2 & x^3 & x^5 \\ | & | & | & | \end{bmatrix} \quad y = \begin{bmatrix} | \\ x^4 \\ | \end{bmatrix}$$

- Now we can **use any feature selection method** to choose j's "neighbours".
  - Forward selection, L1-regularization, ensemble methods, etc.
- Can capture **conditional independence**:
  - Might connect "sick" to "tacos", and "tacos" to "Tuesdays".
    - Without connecting "sick" directly to "Tuesdays".
  - Might connect "grandma" to "mom", and "mom" to "SNP".
    - Without connection "grandma" directly to "SNP".



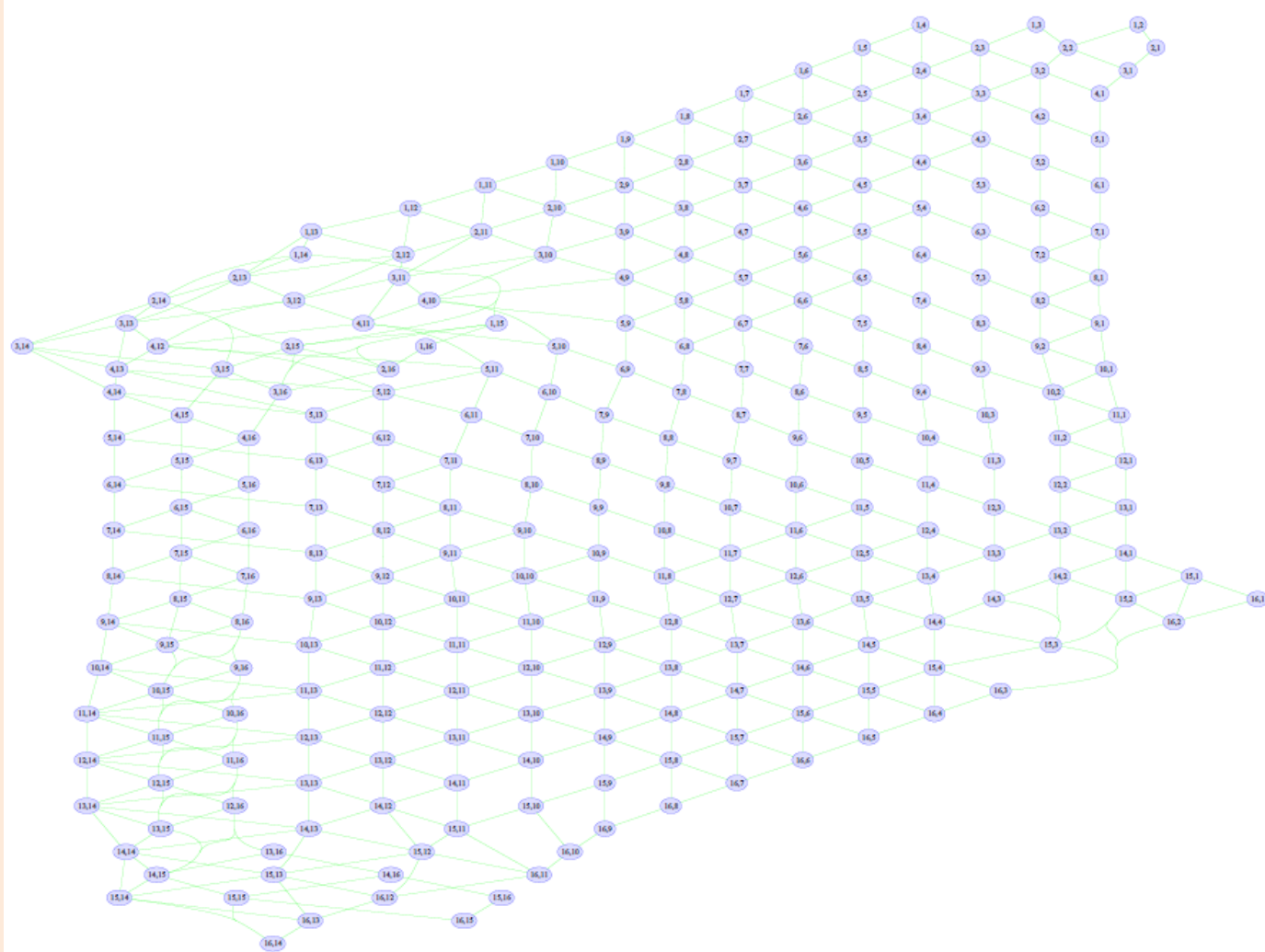
# Dependency Networks

- Dependency network fit to Vancouver rain data (different  $\lambda$  values):



# Dependency Networks

- Variation on dependency networks on digit image pixels:



Another popular structure learning method is the "PC" algorithm.